Sherif Abaza

Global Events and Experiential Marketing Executive

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SUMMARY

Executive leader in global events and experiential marketing with 20+ years of setting strategy, building organisations and owning results. I founded and led **Sphere Events** to a **140-person, USD 8M+ business** serving Siemens, Porsche, Cartier, Ericsson and Emaar, and created its own festival franchises. I then spent **eight years in the C-suite at Withlocals** as Chief Growth Officer and Chief Community Officer, leading growth strategy across 300+ cities, the B2B partnership business and a company-wide pivot. Today I advise global brands on event portfolio strategy and investment, and I have led delivery for **three consecutive COP summits**.

I lead at the level of portfolio and organisation: deciding which experiences deserve investment and what each must achieve for the business, then building the team, agency model and budget discipline to deliver them consistently across markets. I work closely with CEOs, investors and senior stakeholders, and I take established teams through change. AI is part of how I work every day, including two products I have designed and shipped through AI coding agents.

CORE SKILLS

- Global events strategy and portfolio investment
- Executive leadership and organisation design
- P&L, budget and investment ownership
- Brand and experiential marketing
- Flagship events and original event formats
- Executive, VVIP and heads-of-state programmes
- Agency, vendor and partner management
- Leading established teams through change
- Live, virtual and hybrid experiences
- Live, recorded and broadcast production
- Senior stakeholder and C-suite partnership
- AI-led planning and ways of working

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Abaza Business Services · Netherlands / Global

Founder & Managing Director | 2019 – Present

- Advise brands, agencies and organisations on event strategy, portfolio investment and delivery across three continents.
- Event portfolio advisor to **Barry Callebaut**: budget strategy and benchmarking across its global events, identifying around **€711K in savings** across two 2025 events, plus World Chocolate Masters 2026 and a CHF 1M leadership meeting.
- Led delivery for **COP27 (Egypt), COP28 (UAE) and COP29 (Azerbaijan)**, working with heads-of-state, ministerial and senior stakeholder groups and leading multinational teams.
- Strategic delivery partner to global experiential agencies **Jack Morton, Shelton Fleming and Impact XM**, representing them with their clients and leading their programmes in-market.
- Event programme strategy for **NBA** market-entry initiatives in Europe and Africa, working with senior league stakeholders.

Withlocals B.V. · Eindhoven, Netherlands

Chief Community Officer | 2022 – 2026

Chief Growth Officer | 2018 – 2022

- Member of the executive team for eight years, accountable for growth, partnerships and community.
- Set the growth strategy and market priorities that took the company from 50 to **300+ cities in 80+ countries**.
- Created the **B2B partnership business**: commercial model, deal structure and multi-year retention of enterprise accounts.
- Led the company's pivot to virtual experiences, winning **70+ corporate clients in under 90 days** with zero ad spend.
- Set community strategy for a **2,000+ partner network** across 80+ countries.

Sphere Events and Communication · Dubai, UAE

Founder & Managing Director | 2008 – 2018

- Founded and led the company for ten years, growing it from a sole operator to **140 people and USD 8M+** in annual revenue. Set strategy, pricing and investment, with full P&L accountability.
- Built original event properties, **Street Nights, Marina Music Festival and Dubai Chocolate Festival**, into recurring franchises with their own commercial models, sponsors and public-sector partners, reaching audiences of tens of thousands.

- Won and grew multi-year relationships as strategic events partner to **Siemens, Porsche, Cartier, Ericsson and Emaar**.
- Expanded the portfolio into sport and gaming, including the **KitKat 3x3 basketball tournament** and **esports tournaments** with broadcast production and sponsor integration.
- Designed the organisation, leadership structure and operating standards that let a multidisciplinary company scale across formats and markets.

FrontFlip (me360) · Kansas City, USA / MENA
CEO, Middle East & North Africa | 2010 – 2015

- Led the regional business with full P&L ownership. **Raised USD 1.8M** and built a 35-person team across 6+ markets.

Sundance Events · Dubai, UAE
Business Development & Operations Manager | 2006 – 2008

- Built the client base and partner network for corporate and government accounts.

ASDAA Burson-Marsteller · Dubai, UAE
Senior Account Manager | 2004 – 2006

- Communications strategy for Siemens, Adidas and Hilton across the Middle East. Key role producing the **inaugural Dubai International Film Festival**.

AI PROJECTS

- **The Vault (myvaults.io)**: a collectibles management app with AI card identification, designed and shipped by me through AI coding agents.
- **Cards of Kaladan**: a digital card game in closed Android beta, built the same way.
- In event work I use AI for RFP and budget analysis, supplier comparisons, run-of-show and brief drafts, and multilingual attendee communications.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Computer Engineering
Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport, Alexandria, Egypt

LEADERSHIP

AIESEC International
Local Committee President; National Support Team | 1999 – 2004

LANGUAGES

Arabic (native), English (native), French (excellent), Spanish (excellent), Dutch (working), Polish (working), Portuguese, Italian and Romanian (basic)

WORK AUTHORISATION

Dutch (EU) citizen